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FOUR FLIGHTS If it's your first sentence, you go to the classification wing.

Everyone locked down twenty out of twenty-four hours. Unlocked at 0630 for showers and breakfast—you've got an hour to wash, eat, fill your thermos if you have one, interact with whoever else is awake. Then back to your cell.

Lunch comes to you at noon.

1200 to 1300 is yard time—but you choose. If you go out, you stay out until time's up. If you stay in, you stay in. Door locked either way.

Dinner at 1700. Eat in your cell.

Repeat.

The intake process was familiar by then.

Strip search. Photos. Fingerprints.

Sign away whatever personal property you walked in with.

But now I was given a number.

It was on all the uniform they issued. On the card outside my cell. On every piece of paper that would follow me through the system.

Last name and a number.

That's who I was to the staff.

They celled me up with a guy in his late twenties.

Drunk driving charges. Never been in trouble with the law otherwise—a civilian who'd made one bad decision and found himself somewhere he had no framework for understanding.

Tall. Lanky. Petrified of the place.

He barely left his cell. Stayed on his bunk—bottom one was his—and watched the hours pass like he was waiting for someone to tell him it was all a mistake.

First thing I did that night was ask for razors.

Shaved my head clean. Fresh for unlock in the morning.

It wasn't fashion. I was a skinhead. The haircut was part of the uniform. It told people where I stood and who I considered my own.

If you weren't white or European, I didn't want your friendship, your company or anything else from you. I wanted the wing to know exactly what I was when the door opened in the morning. First unlock. I stepped out of the cell with a fresh head and prison blues. The wing was already moving—guys shuffling to showers, queuing for breakfast, filling thermoses. I spotted a couple of whiteboys across the space. Silent recognition. A nod that said I see you without saying anything at all. The politics were already understood: find your people, acknowledge the connection, don't make a performance of it. I went to the yard first chance I got. Wasn't about to be seen as weak or afraid of anything. Tried to get my celly to come with me—fresh air, movement, break up the monotony—but he wasn't keen. Wouldn't even consider it. This concerned me. If he was seen as weak, and I was celled up with him, that weakness could transfer by proxy. Association is currency in there. The wrong association costs you. A couple of days went by. Nothing exciting. There were some lads in the cells across the wing—Perko, Waitane—celled up together, seemed to know each other from outside. They'd noticed I had cigarettes in the yard. Made their way over one afternoon.

“Can we get some tobacco, bro?”

“I'm not your fucken bro”

They were Māori. That was enough for me. I didn't give them the time of day. They offered a trade.

“We've got Matchsticks, glue, sandpaper happy to swap.”

I laughed.

“What the fuck would I want that for?”

Turns out those were valuable commodities inside. Things to do while you're locked down twenty hours a day. You can build things. Pass time. Keep your hands busy and your mind from eating itself. The understanding of that would come in time. There was a young guy in the cell next to mine. Maybe nineteen. Prospecting for Black Power—one of the gangs running through the prison system. Cocky little fucker. Thought he was harder than he was because he was chasing a Patch

A few days in a row, I got woken up early by his music thumping through the wall.

Rap. Loud. Before unlock.

When we got let out one morning, I stopped by his cell on the way to breakfast.

“Hey. Can you keep it down until unlock? Waking me up early, bruva.”

He didn’t take kindly to that.

A whiteboy telling him what to do—that’s how he heard it. Didn’t matter that I was asking, not telling. Didn’t matter that I’d been respectful about it.

He heard disrespect. That was enough.

I told him I wasn’t telling him what to do. I was asking him to be respectful of others since we all had to live there.

Didn’t matter.

One of the older Black Power members had seen me at his cell. Asked what was going on. Whatever the prospect told him, the instruction came back clear: handle it correctly, or be seen as weak.

I picked up my breakfast and went back to my cell.

Sat down at the small desk. Started eating my toast. Cup of tea steaming next to me. Cellmate on his bunk, doing what he always did—existing as quietly as possible.

The prospect walked in.

Mid-bite, he clocked me right in the mouth.

Split my lip. I dropped the toast. Spilled my tea. Knocked my other piece of toast off the desk onto the floor.

So now I was pissed.

Not because he’d hit me. I’d been hit before. I’d be hit again.

Because I no longer had any breakfast. And he’d come into my house to do it.

Some guys outside the cell pulled the door shut.

Keeping watch. Giving us space to figure things out. You didn't interfere. You just made sure no one else did either. He was a Black Power prospect. I was a skinhead. We weren't going to be mates. But I was confident in myself. And I definitely wasn't afraid of a bare-knuckle fight. So that's what he got. Two minutes. Maybe less. When it was over, he had a black eye. His nose was bleeding. Split lip to match the one he'd given me. I wasn't any worse off than when he'd walked in. Just a gash on my knuckles from his front teeth. The door opened. I threw him out. There was a brief look from the others—checking my condition, confirming the outcome. That was it. Once it was finished, it was considered sorted. No retaliation required unless the attack was unprovoked. This wasn't unprovoked. Not by the logic of the place. He'd been sent to establish dominance. It hadn't worked out that way. That was between him and the gang now. Nothing to do with me anymore. The kid next door kept his music down until unlock after that. Whether it was because of the fight or something else, I never found out. Problem solved either way. My cellmate was shell-shocked. He'd watched the whole thing from three feet away. The sudden escalation. The violence. The blood.

It didn't help with his unease about where he'd landed, put it that way. He wasn't dragged into it. He just had another piece of the place to process from the bottom bunk.

After that, I started doing yard time with one of the boys.

We'd run laps. Talk shit. Pass the time.

Then I found out I had a mate in general population—someone from the outside who'd landed before me.

I wanted over there.

Moving to the main wing meant more freedom.

More yard time. More hours unlocked. The system's way of saying you can handle yourself, so we don't need to watch you as closely.

New schedule: Unlock at 0630. Showers, then off to the dining hall for breakfast by 0730.

Back to the wing at 0830. Back to cells at 0900.

Lunch in your cell.

Yard from 1330 to 1600, then back to cells.

Dining hall for dinner at 1700. Back to the wing for rec time at 1730. Cells at 1830 until morning.

More movement. More interaction.

More opportunity for things to go sideways.

They moved me with my classification celly at first.

I did not want this.

He was weak. Getting stood over for a pouch of tobacco every week—someone had figured out he wouldn't fight back, and now it was just a regular tax on his existence.

I couldn't be associated with that.

But there was a spare bunk in my mate Ivian's cell. And a TV. So I got myself moved to his house instead.

I had known Ivian outside, but not well enough that I would have called him a close mate. Sharing a house inside changed that quickly. We went to breakfast, came back to the wing, cleaned, walked the yard, watched television and got locked down together. We both had wing-cleaning work—mopping floors, emptying bins, the usual shit. It bought us extra unlock time and more milk. Outside that sounds like fuck all. In there, extra time with the door open and something more than the standard ration was a decent little win. Perko and Waitane were around all the time as well. In classification they had been the two Māori lads I would not give tobacco to. General population meant I actually had to get to know them. Perko was a funny cunt. Bright, kind, full of energy. Easy to get on with once I actually bothered. Waitane was quiet as fuck. Half Māori, no gang affiliation, in for domestic assault. He kept to himself. Perko did most of the talking. I got to know Waitane properly in there. Joel was the kingpin. Most senior inmate in that wing. In for arson and attempted murder. I knew him from outside. In there, that mattered. General population had its moments. One of them started with a pool game. Jay was Māori. About five foot tall, compact muscle packed into a very small frame. Built like a fucking bulldozer. I knew fuck all about him outside. In the wing he was a cocky fuckwit who moved around like he owned the place.

It was one of those hot days where the wing felt overfilled. No air con. Concrete holding the heat. Everyone shorter with each other than usual.

Yard time came and I didn't take it.

I'd finished my jobs for the day.

My celly was out in the yard. Most of the others too. I stayed inside for a couple of games of pool while the wing was quiet.

Small freedoms. They matter when every hour feels the same.

Yard time ended. The screws brought everyone back in.

I was lining up my shot when Jay walked through.

He came straight to the pool table and used it as a stretching post.

Foot up on the felt.

Doing what he felt like because nobody ever challenged him on it.
In the process, he knocked a couple of balls out of position.
One of them had been set for my shot.
I'd been in plenty of bare-knuckle fights by then. Bigger
men than Jay.

The worst I'd ever come off was a split lip or eyebrow.
So I reacted.

"Seriously? Ya have to fucken do that there?"

Jay stopped and looked up.

The change was instant.

The cocky fuckwit fucking with someone's game disappeared.

His face went hard.

"Who the fuck you talking to?"

He dropped his leg from the table and wrapped his hand around one
of the snooker balls.

Still didn't faze me.

"I'm talking to you. Ya can see we're in the middle of a game. Ya
come in, stretch on the table when I'm about to take a shot, move the
balls around—why the fuck don't you use one of the benches?"

His jaw locked. Eyes fixed on me. He came forward with the snooker
ball clenched in his hand.

"Watch your fucken mouth, white boy, before I cave your
fucken head in."

He launched the ball at the concrete floor. The crack went through the wing. Every head turned. The ball bounced a couple of times before I caught it. I laughed. Continued on with the game. Nothing more came of it. Not that day. The next morning, the nurses collected me. I'd been waiting to get my ears drained. My left ear was basically blocked solid with wax because of a narrow ear canal. I could barely hear through it. The infirmary still had locked doors everywhere, but it felt less like the wing. More clinical. Quieter. I was sitting in the waiting area when I saw him in my peripheral. Joel. Near enough seven foot tall. Arms the size of most people's quads. Long hair tied back in a neat short ponytail. Clean-shaven. Old-school iron cross lad—not patched, but closely affiliated with the Road Knights. A screw was walking him up the stairs. They reached the reinforced glass door. The screw unlocked it, let Joel through, then kept walking down the hallway and disappeared. Joel sat down next to me. That was the pull he had. He knew where I was. He knew we could speak in private. And he'd been knowingly escorted through the prison to do exactly that. We had a quick yarn. I asked how his ma was. He asked how I was settling in. Then the reason he was there.

“So, bruva—what's this shit with Jay you got going on?”

Nothing really, I told him. The fuckwit came in from yard, stretched out over the pool table, fucked our game up. I told him to get the fuck on and he threw his toys out of the cot.

“Hahaha. Good man.”

He paused.

“But he's pissed, bruva. He's come to me for permission to take care of things on the way to mess for dinner.”

Permission.

That's how it worked. Prison politics. Hierarchy. Nothing major happened without the nod from someone who mattered.

“The crazy fuck wants to shank ya and throw ya off the stairs.”

Four flights. That's what separated the wing from the mess hall.

“Who the fuck does that cunt think he is,” I said. “He'd better hope he's fucken quick. You know I'm not gonna let—”

“It's not gonna happen.”

“I didn't give him the green light— which just fucked him off even more.”

Joel looked at me.

“But it's gonna require a public apology for disrespecting him.”

Get fucked. An apology? I'm not—

“And you’re gonna give him that apology. Then steer clear of him before shit gets out of hand and we got a war on our hands.”

I stopped.

All good, bruva. If that’s what you want, then you know I’m not gonna argue.

“Good man.”

The screw appeared from around the corner with the timed precision you could set your watch to. Said nothing as he passed. Unlocked the door.

Joel leaned in.

“Drop back to the end of the line on the way to mess tonight. Don’t get hot-headed with this cunt. Don’t turn your back to him, don’t stop walking up the stairs. Give him the apology. He’s a ticking time bomb and may not even follow orders. Be ready.”

He stood. Turned back as he followed the screw out the door.

“Heil, brother.”

“Heil.”

Until then, Jay had been the five-foot cocky fuckwit who’d fucked with a pool game and lost his temper. Now I knew he’d gone to the most senior inmate in the wing asking permission to stab me and throw me down four flights of stairs. That night, Ivian kept close as we went to dinner. My connection to Joel was the only reason I was still walking. Four flights to the mess hall, Jay somewhere behind me. He came up the stairs and shouldered into me.

“You fucken lucky cunt.”

I kept walking. Didn’t stop. Didn’t turn my back. Yeah, look, Jay—I apologise for any disrespect. It won’t happen again.

“Next time I don’t give a fuck.”

“I’ll cave your fucken head in right there in the wing.”

He stormed ahead, pushing through the others. That was it. An apology I didn't mean, over a fucking pool game, to a man who'd wanted me dead that morning. The rest of Jay's story came later. He'd prospected for Mongrel Mob, then decided they were weak—not hard enough to match the version he'd built up in his head—so he started his own gang. I hadn't known any of that when I mouthed off at him over the pool table. Realistically, knowing it probably wouldn't have changed what I said. On those stairs, though, I was following Joel's orders: keep walking, don't get hot-headed, don't turn my back, apologise. So I did. I stayed out of Jay's way after that. I'd learned what my pride was worth in there. Exactly one walk up four flights of stairs. It wasn't long before the same young prospect from classification was out trying to prove something again. The black eye from the last time was still fading yellow around the edges, which apparently hadn't taught him much. Whatever justification he'd found for himself, this time he started on Waitane. Waitane wanted no part of it. One evening after dinner, during rec, he went to the prospect's cell to put an end to it without a fight. The prospect came at him instead. Waitane dipped underneath him, showed the left just long enough to draw the response, then sent the right hook through fucken hard.

The fuckwit wanted a fight. This one barely had time to become one. His nose got blown out in the process. Waitane's white prison-issue T-shirt was covered in blood. So was the cell wall.

Then I found out the quiet little cunt was a featherweight boxer and a regional champion.

The bit I didn't expect was Waitane.

He panicked.

A few seconds earlier he'd moved with the speed and certainty of somebody who had done that exact work thousands of times. Once it was over, he didn't know what the fuck to do next.

The boys closed around him, enough bodies between the screws and the blood to get him back to his house. He changed. The shirt and the rest of the bloody prison gear went into a laundry bag.

That bag ended up with me.

A few weeks earlier I wouldn't give Waitane tobacco because he was Māori. Now I was carrying his blood-soaked clothes because I didn't want a screw throwing him in the hole.

I knew one of the boys working in laundry. I handed over the bag and made it clear I needed the gear gone.

He took it.

Problem dealt with.

Favours were currency there. You called one, somebody remembered it, and sooner or later somebody wanted something back. Nobody wrote it down because nobody needed to.

Mob was still Mob. Black Power was still Black Power. Road Knights were still Road Knights. I was still a skinhead. Everybody knew who belonged where, who was affiliated and who wasn't.

But the same people still queued for breakfast, crossed the same yard, sat through recreation and disappeared behind the same doors at lock-up. You could play cards with a guy whose patch would have made him an immediate problem outside, then drift back to your own people afterwards. Nobody had forgotten what the patch meant. There was simply more reason inside not to make something of it. Most problems stayed with the two guys involved. Once patches entered the argument, the reach changed. Something personal could very quickly become somebody else's business. Joel was usually the one making sure it didn't. For me I just didn't think it would ever amount to much more than that. Joel was my mate. Our mothers were close friends. In my head, all of that counted for something. I knew exactly what I owed him for: he had stepped in with Jay when I needed him. Even the connection I used for the laundry had come through knowing Joel, adding more weight to the debt. I still figured if he ever called it in, it would be for something small. I never gave the serious version much consideration. It counted for less than I thought. Christian stayed behind most of that rather than putting himself in the middle of it. He was president of the Invercargill chapter of the Road Knights MC and already hotlisted because of it. Keeping himself out of the spotlight was deliberate. Joel handled the politics and most of the day-to-day peace under Christian's instruction. Unless something came directly back to the club—usually one of the younger guys or prospects who hadn't done what they were meant to—Christian had every reason to remain somewhere else. Joe was exactly the sort of person that arrangement allowed me to get on with. He was high-ranking Notorious Mongrel Mob out of Wairoa. Most of the time he was shirtless, with a full-sized patch tattooed across his back. In a mostly white prison in a mostly white South Island town, there was nothing subtle about his presence. And for a while, Joe and I got on. If somebody had told me on first unlock that I would end up playing cards with a senior Mob member or walking laps of the yard with him when Ivian wasn't around, I would have told them to get fucked. But I did. Joe stayed Mob and I stayed me. We dealt cards, walked laps and had a yarn. The affiliations still mattered, but they didn't have to run every fucking minute of the day. Then Joe started running his mouth about the Road Knights and Christian, and that got under my skin fast.

The part of me that had always dealt with disrespect one way wanted to go straight at him. Outside, I probably would have and worried about the rest afterward. Inside, I already knew what came attached to it.

Joe was not some random cunt I could punch and call it settled. He was senior Mob. Christian was president of the local Road Knights chapter. There were men around both of them who would get dragged into whatever started next whether they wanted to or not.

So I swallowed more of Joe's mouth than I wanted to. Fucking hated it, but I understood the calculation.

Then, during rec, I walked past Joe's house and he grabbed me.

Whatever restraint had kept things at words disappeared the second his hands were on me. I kept one leg outside the doorway and slammed both hands against the frame. Joe pulled. I planted myself there and made damn sure he wasn't getting me through that fucking door.

Ivian saw it. So did several other guys.

After a few seconds, Joe let go.

Doing it in the middle of rec left enough witnesses that nobody could rewrite who put hands on who first.

Joel came to me later.

He told me what I was going to do.

I was to invite Joe to my house for coffee. Tell him we should sit down, sort the shit out and put whatever had happened behind us.

That was the story for Joe.

Once he walked through my door, Christian and another prisoner serving life were coming in after him.

They were going to stab him.

The coffee was the bait.

Me asking him over was what made it believable.

Christian had spent most of his sentence deliberately keeping himself out of exactly this sort of spotlight. If he was prepared to walk into my house himself, this had moved well beyond another argument on the wing.

I wasn't expected to carry a weapon.

My job was getting Joe through the fucking door.

My house. My invitation. Joe walking in because I'd asked him to. If he ended up on my floor bleeding heavily, nobody was going to give a fuck that the weapon had been in somebody else's hand. This was the serious version of the debt I'd barely bothered to consider. Joel had stepped in with Jay when I needed him. Now he wanted something back. I knew exactly what I was being used for. I knew how badly it could end once that door closed behind him. None of that stopped me. Recreation came around. Ivian and I sat watching television. Somewhere during that hour I had to stand up, walk over to Joe and ask him in for coffee. Then Joe got up and went for a shower. The shower area was small—three open stalls inside the wing. Joe went in alone. The screws were out of sight. Christian saw the opening before I had to move. He and two other prisoners went into the shower area. It happened quickly and without much noise. Not long afterward the three of them came back out. The weapons stayed behind. Joe was heavily injured. Ivian and I had watched the whole thing from where we were sitting. Then the screws started moving toward the showers and the whole fucking wing went blind at once. People carried on with whatever they had apparently been doing. Ivian knew. I knew. Plenty of others knew. Nobody saw shit. My calculation was immediate: I did not have to bring Joe through that fucking cell door. Fucken result. I had not refused Joel and I had not changed my mind. Joe went for a shower before I had to move. A few minutes separated me from being the man who personally invited a senior Mob member into his cell for Christian and the other prisoner to come in after him and stab him. Through those weeks, Stacey came every Sunday. When I was sentenced, a new visiting hall was still being built—modern, no direct contact between inmate and visitor, the setup you see in movies. Because it wasn't finished, most of my visits were held in the gymnasium instead.

Old school-assembly bench seats.

All inmates in bright orange overalls pulled on over prison blues and zipped from the back. A screw would security-tag the zipper, wrist cuffs and ankle cuffs.

But you got to sit with your visitor.

She'd walk ninety minutes each way to sit with me for an hour. Rain, hail, didn't matter. She'd moved in with her mum so she was in the same city as the prison.

She banked enough money each week for my smokes and a pack of choc chip cookies.

Twice a week, a letter would arrive— always a week behind because of processing.

The first half was updates. The second half was filthy.

Which was great.

I never told her any of the heavy stuff.

The fight. Jay. The stairs. None of it.

There was nothing she could do about any of it from outside.

She was betting on me before there was anything to bet on.

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The parole board happened a few weeks later.

My brother had wagged school to be there. He was fifteen—not allowed into the prison due to not being eighteen. But somehow he'd managed to get in with Stacey as a support person.

First time I'd seen him in three months. Since the courtroom, when I'd mouthed catch ya on the flipside and given him that salute.

I had no idea he was going to be there.

That was a real buzz.

The board meetings were held in the admin block.

It barely looked like the same institution. Marble floors. Big timber doors. A long solid-wood table. The waiting area outside was much plainer. Almost a corridor with standard steel-framed desk chairs lined against the wall. Behind the big doors was the board. Six of them, I think. Three women, three men. All sitting along one side of the table. Single chair on the other. Support people weren't allowed in. They asked for supporting documents. Letters from family. My behaviour record from the prison. Whether I was affiliated with any gangs. Then why I believed I should be granted home detention for the remainder of my sentence. I made my case. Then they sent me back out to the waiting area while they made their decision. I'd barely walked out. The door was still closing when they called me back in. That fast. They'd already decided before I'd finished speaking. An older lady read out the decision. Early fifties. Chair of the board. She wasted no time. The application was denied due to my extensive history of breaching bail conditions. Every single bail condition ever imposed on me between the ages of thirteen and nineteen—some of them breached multiple times. I had never completed any community work-based sentencing. Never paid any reparation. She said it with a tight smile. What did you expect? I wouldn't be eligible to reapply for a further six months. Which basically meant I was doing the full stretch. I walked back out to the corridor. Stacey was gutted. My brother just looked at me. I wasn't fazed by it. It is what it is. The walk back to the wing was short. Escorted. Nothing to say.